

The TV was in another room, switched off.

And then, over our meat-and-three-veg, we spoke about what had happened in our day.

We discussed the news, and politics, and the world.

We listened to Dad talk about what was happening in the family business.

We watched Mum and Dad talk about the big purchases they were saving up for.

We got paid pocket money.

And we all pitched in and helped clean up. It was a chain gang: Dad washed the dishes, my sister dried, and I put them away. (Fun fact: to this day my father still washes the dishes by hand, even though he has a dishwasher. He's suspicious of new technology.)

Up until the point my little mate came over, I never knew dinners could be anything different. It's kind of like how you pick your footy team—it's not so much a conscious choice; it's just how things have always been in your family, and you'd support your dad's team or else!

Little did I know our dinners were like a form of brainwashing water torture:

Drip. Drip. Drip(ping).

As an adult, I can now look back on things and quite confidently say . . .

I need to check my cholesterol.

Just kidding.

What I *can* say is that our family dinners were something special, and my parents were employing some serious science (even though they didn't know it).

A better bet than a \$35 000-a-year private school